

Many Moves to Glory

Vishwanathan Anand refused to lose his way in the labyrinth of chess politics in pursuit of the world championship title. While others lobbied, he just played. An appreciation.

■ **By Devangshu Datta**

In 1886, a few years before Jamsaheb invented the leg-gance, William Steinitz of Prague beat Johannes Zukertort of Berlin to become the first world chess champion. It took 121 years for an outsider, Viswanathan Anand, to transport that title to the wider world outside Europe and the Americas.

Chess is mainstream in its popularity—161 nations participated in the last chess Olympiad. But it is essentially Eurocentric in culture. Steinitz's heirs include 10 Europeans (nine Soviet citizens), one Cuban and an American. In that context, Anand's world title at Mexico is an enormous achievement. Only extreme talent and hard work can compensate for an early lack of coaching.

Chess has a vast body of theory about the best way to deploy pieces. Russians learn this through the distilled experience of senior pros. Anand taught himself. While others went into Mexico with teams of seconds and top-end hardware, he carried one laptop and employed one second in Peter Heine Nielsen of Denmark.

What makes his victory amazing is that the odds had been stoutly against the Indian Grandmaster (GM) through an accident of history. About the time Anand hit maturity, the organisation of international chess came apart. In 1991, the 22-year-old lost a quarter-final match to former world champion Anatoly Karpov. That was the last undisputed title cycle until

the Mexico event in 2007. In 1993, champion Garry Kasparov and challenger Nigel Short left the World Chess Federation (FIDE). They founded the PCA (Professional Chess Association) and held a match, which Kasparov won by a massive margin.

Like boxing with its alphabet soup organisations, PCA and FIDE held concurrent title qualifiers. Anand played Kasparov in a PCA title-match on September 11, 1995 on the roof-top of the World Trade Centre. The Indian Grandmaster was raw and lost despite an early lead. Intel sponsored PCA in 1995 but when the chip-maker withdrew support, PCA imploded. World No.

TOP HOMBRE: Anand in Mexico City as undisputed world champ



While others went into Mexico with teams of seconds and top-end hardware, Anand carried one laptop and hired one second.

1 Kasparov remained an alternate power centre and his refusal to play the FIDE title cycle devalued it.

In the late 1990s, the FIDE world championship was a free-for-all. Federations with clout could get concessions for their title-aspirants. While Kasparov, Karpov, Vladimir Kramnik, Bulgarian Veselin Topalov, and others had influential backers, the All India Chess Federation (AICF) lacked both negotiating skills and leverage.

As a result, Anand suffered. In 1998, he beat eight opponents over two-game matches in 16 days to qualify for a 'title match'. On day 19, he met Karpov, who at the behest of the Russian Chess Federation (RCF), had been seeded into the travesty of a final

without having played a game. Exhausted, Anand lost a tie-breaker. A year later, under more equal conditions, he beat Karpov 5-0.

In 2000, the maestro from Chennai had a choice. Either take on Kasparov in uncertain conditions with an uncertain validity and an uncertain prize money or play the FIDE series where the prize money, at least, was guaranteed.

When negotiations with Kasparov broke down Anand played the FIDE series instead and won. That made him a world champion but not an undisputed world champion. Kramnik had beaten Kasparov to lay claim to the title as well.

FIDE again tried to unify the title in 2003-04 with an agreement hammered out in Prague during the World Cup where the top 64 participated. Anand won the Cup, was rated No. 2, and voted Chess Player of the Year by